

Instant DELIVERY

In the state with India's largest health care network, women are increasingly seeking cesarean sections, sparking fears of health risks



Photography by HE MANI CHAWLA.
Photo imaging by SAURABH SINGH /
www.makelifeimages.com

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Reena, 20, was nine months pregnant but was not prepared to go through labour pains to have her first child. Her husband, who works in Dubai, concurred with her decision on opting for a cesarean section. Her doctor at a private hospital was more than willing to go by what her family wanted since it was a win-win situation. The patient wanted it, the hospital would get Rs 30,000 as a fee instead of the Rs 4,000 it charges for a normal delivery. Last month, Reena delivered a healthy boy without pain, thanks to a Cesarean Section (CS).

In places like Perinthalmanna in Kerala's northern Malappuram district, there is nothing more lucrative than running a hospital. The 34-sq km town with a population of about 50,000 has as many as 400 registered doctors and 25 hospitals, including three with super speciality tertiary care facilities. Kerala, with the country's largest health care network and the best health indicators, tops in the incidence of CS. The CS rate in Kerala is 30.1 per cent, thrice the national average. And unlike the rest of the country, there is hardly any major rural-urban difference in its incidence in Kerala. "Even developed countries like the US have reported figures around 25 per cent," points out N. Ajith Kumar, director of the Centre for Socio-Economic and Environmental Studies, Kochi. Of the 7,500 childbirths at the century-old Government Women and Child Hospital in Thiruvananthapuram last year, 3,266 were by CS.

Studies from around the world have shown that an unwarranted CS leads to health risks to mothers such as injuries to uterus, bladder and also possibilities of severe infections, haemorrhage, and respiratory distress to babies. According to the protocol laid down by the WHO, medical

	SEX RATIO**	INFANT MORTALITY RATE
INDIA	933/1,000	57/1,000
KERALA	1058/1,000	15/1,000